In TamilNadu, the image of deities attached to composite columns gradually freed themselves from the core column. The 1000-pillar *mandapam* of the Meenakshi-Sundareswarar temple, Pudumandapam at Madurai, Rathi Mandapam at Tirukkurungudi and Vanamamalai Temple at Nanguneri are illustrious examples for the *mandapam* architecture of this period.



1000-Pillar Mandapam, Madurai Meenakshiamman Temple

The pillars of this period are more decorative than the previous period. Monolithic gigantic *yazhi* pillars, horse pillars with life-size portraits of mythological and royal family members, common folk, animals and floral works were made. Musical pillars were the peculiar feature of this time. A sitting lion at the top of the pillars is a common feature in the *mandapams*. The windows are carved out on the walls of the sanctum and *mandapams*.

The Jalagandeshwara temple at Vellore, the temples at Thadikompu near Dindugal and Krishnapuram near Tirunelveli and the Subramanya shrine in the Big Temple Thanjavur are most remarkable edifices of this time. Vijayanagar and Nayak paintings are seen at Varadharaja Perumal temple at Kanchipuram, Kudalazhagar Temple at Madurai and the temples of Srivilliputhur, Tiruvellarai, Azhaharkoil, Tiruvannamalai and Srirangam. The paintings mostly have the stories from Ramayana, palace scenes and mythological stories.



Sculptures in Varatharaja Temple, Kanchipuram

Modern Period (After A.D. 1600)

The Sethupathis, as the feudatories of Madurai Nayaks, ruled Ramanathapuram and contributed to the Ramanathaswamy temple architecture. In the temple of Rameswaram, the predominance of corridors is striking. It is claimed that this temple has the longest set of corridors in the world. The temple has three sets of corridors. The outer set of the temple's corridors has a height of almost 7 metres and stretches for about 120 metres in both the eastern and western directions. The corridors to the north and to the south, on the other hand, are about 195 metres in length. The outer corridor is also remarkable for the number of pillars that support it, which is over 1200 in number. Moreover, many of these pillars are decorated by ornate carvings. The innermost set of corridors is the oldest of the three.

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